

Remembering the masters



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“As a result of the insecurities raised by sci-fi authors like HG Wells, technology is constantly being pushed to save our race...”

Just because you get older in life doesn't mean you have to lose your sense of wonder. With age and experience comes the understanding – at least to some degree – as to how the world around us functions. If nothing else, at least it lets you appreciate things that others do, in areas concerning your life or interests. Sports and reading have been two of my hobbies, for as long as I can remember.

While last month's Rio Olympics has left me starry-eyed by seeing the likes of Michael Phelps, Usain Bolt, and Dipa Karmakar excel in their individual capacity, I can't help but wonder at how sports is being revolutionized by technology. Whether it's day-to-day training, gadgets and sensors to track athletes' vitals and help them attain optimal fitness, get focused and in the zone before a competition, or help them recuperate and relax after a strenuous workout, I think it's easy to say that sports is benefiting from advancements in technology and big data analytics. It doesn't take a huge leap of imagination to wonder what would happen if Indian athletes (like Dipa Karmakar) had a state-of-the-art, tech-infused coaching system and facilities to benefit from? Our Rio medal harvest would certainly have been more bountiful.

I am a sports fan through and through, but because I write for a living, I think I have a slightly greater appreciation for writers now more than ever. Writers who, with their work, continue to have a mesmerizing effect on not just me but a lot of others here at Digit and beyond. Writers of science fiction, especially. Reading their stories again as an adult just leaves you feeling more like a kid again. Albeit a restlessly curious 30-year-old kid, left with more questions than answers. That's the sort of effect HG Wells can still have on you!

Through such epics as *The Time Machine*, *The Invisible Man* and *War of The Worlds*, HG Wells left a deep impression on his readers – including myself. The idea that you could move back and forth in time, revisit the past and get a glimpse of the future blew my mind away. And the fact that aliens will one day appear on earth and try to destroy it, made me more inquisitive about space in general. In the form of cartoons like *The Jetsons* (animated cartoon series of a human family living in space, for the uninitiated) and

Marvin the Martian (from Looney Tunes), I had tasted themes from HG Wells' work before, but only when I first read his books that I truly understood how they'd sparked modern human thought and possibilities. And to think all of this came from a guy at the turn of the 19th century is beyond amazing!

For all his flights of fancy and pioneering ideas, looking back at HG Wells' work now I can't help but magnify the sense of pessimism and doom it portrays – something that I couldn't really grasp in my joyful, optimistic youth. Perhaps not in my lifetime but the fact that this world's going to end one day, humanity's going to degenerate, that all will be lost are all undercurrents of Wells' central theme in some of his seminal work. While, yes, global warming and rapid climate change is a worrisome trend, and that depleting natural resources may push the world towards an eventual thermonuclear WWII, but as someone who's witnessed technology's impact on our lives I can't help but think that there's a silver lining waiting to reveal itself. As a result of the insecurities raised by sci-fi authors like HG Wells, technology is constantly being pushed to save ourselves from earth's climate, find alternative sources of energy that would sustain our planet longer, build better humans through genetic engineering, and take unsurpassed leaps into space unlike we've ever done before.

It's all thanks to writers like HG Wells and their compelling vision of the future that gave wings to the imagination of countless others who followed, allowing us to build the world we live in, currently. But don't forget that we could only build that world because of the tools that technological progress provided us.

As I celebrate the birth anniversary of HG Wells this month, I couldn't think of a better way to honour his legacy than by making him the topic of my column this month – along with sports, of course, the undeclared love of my life. But more importantly, I wanted to start a conversation with you, dear reader. Which sci-fi writers have sparked your imagination and how? 

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